posture towards countries in Asia and the world? What does the current geopolitical landscape look like from the vantage point of Beijing? If indeed we are on course towards a Chinese-dominated Asia and a Chinese-led global order, what would they look like? And what options would India have to safeguard and to promote its own interests in such an adverse geopolitical landscape? These are the questions which this and the concluding chapter will attempt to answer.

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We may divide China's forty-year transformational period into three phases:

The first phase covers the first decade of Reform and Opening-Up, from 1978 to 1989. Since US President Nixon's historic visit to Beijing in 1972, the two countries had forged a virtual alliance against the Soviet Union. The US was ready and willing to strengthen Chinese economic and military capabilities to enable it to deter the security threat from the Soviet Union. The US move was followed by several Western allies of the US, Japan and South-East Asian countries establishing normal relations with China and opening up their markets to their new partner. The constraint on the scale of this US and Western support was only China's own commitment to a policy of self-reliance. When China under Deng Xiaoping launched the Economic Reform and Opening-Up Policy, its alliance with the US and access to American allies in Europe and Asia, in particular Japan, enabled large flows of both capital and technology and, as mentioned in the previous chapter, created opportunities for several thousand Chinese students to be educated in the best universities in the West and Japan. This favourable geopolitical environment over a decade was critical to the early success of Deng's strategy of economic revival and growth. It helped lay a solid foundation for the country's further growth, despite the geopolitical landscape turning negative after the pro-democracy demonstrations in the capital's historic Tiananmen Square and its violent suppression in June 1989.

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